

Introduction: Mental health disorders and cancer diagnosis

Delays in cancer diagnosis affect outcomes, survival, and costs, and are especially common in patients with pre-existing anxiety and/or depression. Previous research indicates these patients are less likely to be referred for cancer investigations from primary care and more likely to receive a diagnosis through emergency routes. These patients are also more likely to express suicidal thoughts than patients without anxiety or depression, and combining this with being investigated and potentially diagnosed with cancer can have a big impact on a person's mental wellbeing. Consequently, patients with anxiety and/or depression are at increased risk of late-stage cancer diagnosis, poorer clinical outcomes, and higher associated healthcare costs.

This study forms part of a wider programme of research evaluating a communication tool designed to improve early cancer diagnosis pathways in general practice for people with anxiety and/or depression. You have previously been involved in piloting this tool. The current stage of our research focuses on assessing the cost-effectiveness of the intervention if introduced more widely across the NHS. In order to do this we are developing an economic model which simulates patient pathways from first GP visit through referrals or repeats to cancer diagnosis via referral, emergency, or outpatient/inpatient detection. The model evaluates the health benefits against the cost of the communication tool. Some key inputs for our economic model are not available from existing data sources, and as an alternative we require clinical input to inform these estimates. We are requesting your help with this.

You will first be guided through the remainder of this interactive tool where we will ask you a series of questions. You are not expected to know the answer to all of these questions.

Some of the questions will be about things where you can express your answers relatively easily, but others may require some thinking. Just express how uncertain you are about the questions in your response (we will show you how to do this shortly).

The responses you give for these questions will be used directly to help us inform the gaps in our economic model to help us understand the potential "value for money" of the communication tool. The second part of the appointment will consist of interview-style questions. These questions aim to capture clinical insights that will inform the structure and assumptions of our economic model.

Please click on 'Next' to continue

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